—Director of Central Intelligence Stansfield Turner felt it was; Vance disagreed. Defense Secretary Harold Brown felt that Moscow was in a better position with Delhi than five years before because of the leverage provided by their supply of military equipment.[176]

For this and other reasons, the Soviet Union remained India's most essential partner. Delhi had not been too happy about the lack of Soviet movement on disarmament or Moscow's expanding influence and presence in Afghanistan or the Indian Ocean region—developments Carter had continued to highlight to Desai.[177] But that unhappiness did not translate to a willingness to ignore Moscow's sensitivities because Delhi continued to need Soviet support. Thus, when Desai wrote to Carter that September saying he was committed to seeking improved relations with China, he stressed it would not be "at the cost of complicating" India's relations with Moscow.[178] The prime minister would not even publicize his phone call to congratulate Carter for facilitating the Camp David accords lest it looked like he was taking sides against the Soviets.[179]

The Indian government was, however, not going to let the Soviet Union veto its reconciliation with China. Vajpayee met with Huang in New York and said he was impressed with Chinese sincerity to move forward. He expressed optimism about his upcoming visit to China, which was scheduled for the end of October.[180] Key questions about that trip, an Indian commentator noted, were "whether to move away from Moscow and closer to Peking and how far we should travel in either direction and at what speed."[181]

At a conference of Indian army commanders, Indian defense minister Jagjivan Ram reiterated the hope for an improvement with China. But he also pointed to Chinese efforts to "feverishly arm itself" and increase its capabilities in Tibet. Ram also mentioned what had become another source of concern for India—China's increasing access to the Western arms market, and American attempts to scuttle India's purchase of deep penetration strike aircraft. Vajpayee had brought up both subjects with Vance in October.[182] And Ram expressed disappointment that the US had not permitted Sweden to sell Viggen aircraft to India (though the US was unable to prevent Britain from selling the Jaguar, and Washington was not altogether unhappy that Delhi had made a "Western" purchase).[183]